



India and the Middle East

In India and the neighboring regions, a variety of herbal traditions continue to flourish. Ayurveda is the main system of healing in India, but Unani Tibb, traditional Arabic medicine, and Siddha, practised in Tamil areas of southern India and Sri Lanka, are also major herbal traditions.

The name Ayurveda derives from two Indian words: *ayur* meaning longevity, and *veda* meaning knowledge or science. Ayurveda is as much a way of life as a system of medicine, and encompasses science, religion, and philosophy. Its ultimate aim, drawing on its many different practices—yoga and meditation, for example—is to promote self-realization and a harmonious relationship with the world.

Early Origins

Ancient Indian culture developed around 5,000 years ago along the banks of the Indus river in northern India. This is thought of as a time of great spiritual enlightenment, with knowledge and wisdom being transmitted orally from teacher to student over many generations, and eventually set down in Sanskrit poetry known as the *Vedas*. These writings, dating from approximately 1500 BCE, distilled the prevailing historical, religious, philosophical, and medical knowledge, and form the basis of Indian culture. The most important of these texts are the *Rig Veda* and the *Atharva Veda*.

In about 400 BCE, the first Ayurvedic medical school was founded by Punarvasu Atreya. He and his pupils recorded medical knowledge in treatises that would in turn influence Charaka, the scholar who is thought to have written the *Charaka Samhita*. This compendium of writings, in the form that it has come down to us, dates from around 100 CE and describes 341 plant medicines as well as medicines of animal and mineral origin. The second major work was the *Susruta Samhita*, dating from around the same time; it displays detailed knowledge of surgery, especially plastic surgery, and is still consulted today.

The Influence of Ayurveda

Other traditions of medicine share common roots with Ayurveda, and Ayurveda has some claim to being the oldest surviving medical tradition in the world. From the time of the Buddha (563–483 BCE) onward, Ayurvedic medical ideas and practices spread across Asia, accompanying the spread of Buddhism itself. Buddhism, and Ayurvedic approaches to medicine, strongly influenced the development of Tibetan medicine, and these ideas in turn combined fruitfully with traditional Chinese medicine. Ancient civilizations of East and



Cloves have been used medicinally for thousands of years in India. The flower buds are dried in the open air.

Myrtle (*Myrtus communis*, p. 239) is cultivated for its oil, which is used for bronchitis.

Castor oil plant (*Ricinus communis*, p. 262) is prescribed in India for nervous disorders.

Garlic pearls

Garlic capsules

Garlic cloves

Garlic (*Allium sativum*, p. 59) is a key herb in Ayurvedic medicine, highly regarded for its detoxifying properties.

Cloves (*Eugenia caryophyllata*, p. 97) help infections ranging from scabies to cholera.

Storax (*Liquidambar orientalis*, p. 229) is an important ingredient in Western cough mixtures.

Powdered garlic

Licorice (*Glycyrrhiza glabra*, p. 101) grows wild in India. It is an indispensable medicinal herb.

Dried licorice root

Powdered licorice root

Fresh licorice